Pre-Authorisation Requirement Matrix

MERIDIAN HEALTH PARTNERS
OPERATIONS POLICY MANUAL
POLICY REF: MHP-OP-2024-PA4
SUBJECT: PRE-AUTHORISATION REQUIREMENTS AND ESCALATION PROTOCOLS
EFFECTIVE DATE: 1 JANUARY 2024

1.0 PURPOSE AND SCOPE
1.1 This policy establishes mandatory pre-authorisation requirements, clinical documentation thresholds, approval processing timelines, and appeal routes across all fourteen Meridian Health Partners sites for patients enrolled in MERIDIAN-GOLD, MERIDIAN-SILVER, MERIDIAN-BRONZE, and CIVIC-BASE insurance plans.
1.2 Compliance with this policy is mandatory for all clinical, scheduling, and billing personnel.

2.0 GENERAL RULES BY SERVICE TYPE
2.1 Consultations (CARD-CONS, ORTH-CONS, DERM-CONS, ENDO-CONS, GAST-CONS, PULM-CONS, NEUR-CONS, ENT-CONS) never require pre-authorisation under any plan.
2.2 Laboratory work and diagnostic testing classified as lab tests (DERM-BIOP, ENDO-PANL, PULM-PFT, ENT-AUDI) never require pre-authorisation under any plan.
2.3 Imaging services require pre-authorisation based on plan tier as follows: MERIDIAN-GOLD requires no pre-authorisation; MERIDIAN-SILVER requires pre-authorisation with a 3 business day approval window; MERIDIAN-BRONZE requires pre-authorisation with a 5 business day approval window; CIVIC-BASE requires pre-authorisation with a 5 business day approval window.
2.4 Procedures require pre-authorisation under every plan with the following approval windows: MERIDIAN-GOLD requires 2 business days; MERIDIAN-SILVER requires 3 business days; MERIDIAN-BRONZE requires 5 business days; CIVIC-BASE requires 7 business days.
2.5 Coverage exclusions: CARD-CATH and ORTH-ARTH are not covered at all under the CIVIC-BASE plan.

3.0 CARDIOVASCULAR SERVICES
3.1 CARD-CONS (Cardiology Consultation, list price $220): Pre-authorisation is not required under MERIDIAN-GOLD, MERIDIAN-SILVER, MERIDIAN-BRONZE, or CIVIC-BASE. Clinical documentation needed: standard outpatient referral note. Appeal route if denied: Medical Director Review via Dr. Aris Vance.
3.2 CARD-ECHO (Echocardiogram, list price $950): Pre-authorisation is not required under MERIDIAN-GOLD; required under MERIDIAN-SILVER with a 3 business day approval window; required under MERIDIAN-BRONZE with a 5 business day approval window; required under CIVIC-BASE with a 5 business day approval window. Clinical documentation needed: cardiologist referral and recent electrocardiogram showing structural or arrhythmic indication. Appeal route if denied: Independent External Review Panel (IERP).
3.3 CARD-CATH (Cardiac Catheterisation, list price $7,800): Pre-authorisation is required under MERIDIAN-GOLD (2 business days), MERIDIAN-SILVER (3 business days), and MERIDIAN-BRONZE (5 business days); not covered under CIVIC-BASE. Clinical documentation needed: recent abnormal echocardiogram, treadmill stress test report, and attending cardiologist attestation. Appeal route if denied: Meridian Utilization Review Committee (URC) Level 2 Appeal.

4.0 ORTHOPAEDIC SERVICES

4.1 ORTH-CONS (Orthopaedics Consultation, list price $200): Pre-authorisation is not required under MERIDIAN-GOLD, MERIDIAN-SILVER, MERIDIAN-BRONZE, or CIVIC-BASE. Clinical documentation needed: primary care physician referral noting joint pain or musculoskeletal deficit. Appeal route if denied: Medical Director Review via Dr. Aris Vance.

4.2 ORTH-MRI (MRI Knee, list price $1,400): Pre-authorisation is not required under MERIDIAN-GOLD; required under MERIDIAN-SILVER with a 3 business day approval window; required under MERIDIAN-BRONZE with a 5 business day approval window; required under CIVIC-BASE with a 5 business day approval window. Clinical documentation needed: orthopaedic consultation notes documenting failed 6-week conservative physical therapy. Appeal route if denied: Independent External Review Panel (IERP).

4.3 ORTH-ARTH (Knee Arthroscopy, list price $6,200): Pre-authorisation is required under MERIDIAN-GOLD (2 business days), MERIDIAN-SILVER (3 business days), and MERIDIAN-BRONZE (5 business days); not covered under CIVIC-BASE. Clinical documentation needed: positive diagnostic MRI report and orthopaedic surgeon operative plan. Appeal route if denied: Meridian Utilization Review Committee (URC) Level 2 Appeal.

5.0 DERMATOLOGY SERVICES

5.1 DERM-CONS (Dermatology Consultation, list price $160): Pre-authorisation is not required under MERIDIAN-GOLD, MERIDIAN-SILVER, MERIDIAN-BRONZE, or CIVIC-BASE. Clinical documentation needed: referral indicating rash, lesion, or skin anomaly. Appeal route if denied: Medical Director Review via Dr. Aris Vance.

5.2 DERM-BIOP (Skin Biopsy Pathology, list price $380): Pre-authorisation is not required under MERIDIAN-GOLD, MERIDIAN-SILVER, MERIDIAN-BRONZE, or CIVIC-BASE. Clinical documentation needed: clinical photograph and dermatologist diagnostic suspicion report. Appeal route if denied: Laboratory Quality Assurance Committee.

5.3 DERM-EXCI (Lesion Excision, list price $1,150): Pre-authorisation is required under MERIDIAN-GOLD (2 business days), MERIDIAN-SILVER (3 business days), MERIDIAN-BRONZE (5 business days), and CIVIC-BASE (7 business days). Clinical documentation needed: prior biopsy pathology report confirming malignancy or atypical dysplasia. Appeal route if denied: Meridian Utilization Review Committee (URC) Level 2 Appeal.

6.0 ENDOCRINOLOGY SERVICES

6.1 ENDO-CONS (Endocrinology Consultation, list price $190): Pre-authorisation is not required under MERIDIAN-GOLD, MERIDIAN-SILVER, MERIDIAN-BRONZE, or CIVIC-BASE. Clinical documentation needed: metabolic symptom history. Appeal route if denied: Medical Director Review via Dr. Aris Vance.

6.2 ENDO-PANL (Thyroid Function Panel, list price $140): Pre-authorisation is not required under MERIDIAN-GOLD, MERIDIAN-SILVER, MERIDIAN-BRONZE, or CIVIC-BASE. Clinical documentation needed: physician order detailing suspected thyroid dysfunction. Appeal route if denied: Laboratory Quality Assurance Committee.

6.3 ENDO-FNAB (Thyroid Fine-Needle Aspiration, list price $900): Pre-authorisation is required under MERIDIAN-GOLD (2 business days), MERIDIAN-SILVER (3 business days), MERIDIAN-BRONZE (5 business days), and CIVIC-BASE (7 business days). Clinical documentation needed: thyroid ultrasound report showing nodule TIRADS classification 4 or 5. Appeal route if denied: Meridian Utilization Review Committee (URC) Level 2 Appeal.

7.0 GASTROENTEROLOGY SERVICES

7.1 GAST-CONS (Gastroenterology Consultation, list price $210): Pre-authorisation is not required under MERIDIAN-GOLD, MERIDIAN-SILVER, MERIDIAN-BRONZE, or CIVIC-BASE. Clinical documentation needed: GI symptom ledger. Appeal route if denied: Medical Director Review via Dr. Aris Vance.

7.2 GAST-USND (Abdominal Ultrasound, list price $520): Pre-authorisation is not required under MERIDIAN-GOLD; required under MERIDIAN-SILVER with a 3 business day approval window; required under MERIDIAN-BRONZE with a 5 business day approval window; required under CIVIC-BASE with a 5 business day approval window. Clinical documentation needed: physician notes detailing right upper quadrant pain or elevated liver enzymes. Appeal route if denied: Independent External Review Panel (IERP).

7.3 GAST-COLO (Colonoscopy, list price $2,600): Pre-authorisation is required under MERIDIAN-GOLD (2 business days), MERIDIAN-SILVER (3 business days), MERIDIAN-BRONZE (5 business days), and CIVIC-BASE (7 business days). Clinical documentation needed: screening eligibility confirmation or diagnostic indication notes (rectal bleeding, anemia). Appeal route if denied: Meridian Utilization Review Committee (URC) Level 2 Appeal.

8.0 PULMONOLOGY SERVICES

8.1 PULM-CONS (Pulmonology Consultation, list price $200): Pre-authorisation is not required under MERIDIAN-GOLD, MERIDIAN-SILVER, MERIDIAN-BRONZE, or CIVIC-BASE. Clinical documentation needed: referral noting dyspnea or chronic cough. Appeal route if denied: Medical Director Review via Dr. Aris Vance.

8.2 PULM-PFT (Pulmonary Function Test, list price $310): Pre-authorisation is not required under MERIDIAN-GOLD, MERIDIAN-SILVER, MERIDIAN-BRONZE, or CIVIC-BASE. Clinical documentation needed: pulmonologist or primary care order with respiratory ICD-10 code. Appeal route if denied: Laboratory Quality Assurance Committee.

8.3 PULM-BRON (Bronchoscopy, list price $3,400): Pre-authorisation is required under MERIDIAN-GOLD (2 business days), MERIDIAN-SILVER (3 business days), MERIDIAN-BRONZE (5 business days), and CIVIC-BASE (7 business days). Clinical documentation needed: chest CT scan report and pulmonology procedural justification. Appeal route if denied: Meridian Utilization Review Committee (URC) Level 2 Appeal.

9.0 NEUROLOGY SERVICES

9.1 NEUR-CONS (Neurology Consultation, list price $230): Pre-authorisation is not required under MERIDIAN-GOLD, MERIDIAN-SILVER, MERIDIAN-BRONZE, or CIVIC-BASE. Clinical documentation needed: neurological symptom intake form. Appeal route if denied: Medical Director Review via Dr. Aris Vance.

9.2 NEUR-MRI (MRI Brain, list price $1,650): Pre-authorisation is not required under MERIDIAN-GOLD; required under MERIDIAN-SILVER with a 3 business day approval window; required under MERIDIAN-BRONZE with a 5 business day approval window; required under CIVIC-BASE with a 5 business day approval window. Clinical documentation needed: neurologist clinical notes documenting persistent focal neurological deficits or chronic intractable headache. Appeal route if denied: Independent External Review Panel (IERP).

9.3 NEUR-NCS (Nerve Conduction Study, list price $780): Pre-authorisation is required under MERIDIAN-GOLD (2 business days), MERIDIAN-SILVER (3 business days), MERIDIAN-BRONZE (5 business days), and CIVIC-BASE (7 business days). Clinical documentation needed: neurology consultation record indicating suspected radiculopathy or peripheral neuropathy. Appeal route if denied:

Meridian Utilization Review Committee (URC) Level 2 Appeal.

10.0 OTOLARYNGOLOGY (ENT) SERVICES

10.1 ENT-CONS (ENT Consultation, list price $170): Pre-authorisation is not required under MERIDIAN-GOLD, MERIDIAN-SILVER, MERIDIAN-BRONZE, or CIVIC-BASE. Clinical documentation needed: referral for otic, nasal, or throat pathology. Appeal route if denied: Medical Director Review via Dr. Aris Vance.

10.2 ENT-AUDI (Audiometry, list price $150): Pre-authorisation is not required under MERIDIAN-GOLD, MERIDIAN-SILVER, MERIDIAN-BRONZE, or CIVIC-BASE. Clinical documentation needed: physician order for hearing loss evaluation. Appeal route if denied: Laboratory Quality Assurance Committee.

10.3 ENT-SEPT (Septoplasty, list price $5,400): Pre-authorisation is required under MERIDIAN-GOLD (2 business days), MERIDIAN-SILVER (3 business days), MERIDIAN-BRONZE (5 business days), and CIVIC-BASE (7 business days). Clinical documentation needed: ENT operative plan and photographic or rhinometric proof of structural nasal airway obstruction failing medical management. Appeal route if denied: Meridian Utilization Review Committee (URC) Level 2 Appeal.

11.0 GOVERNANCE AND ENFORCEMENT

11.1 Any service rendered without obtaining prior approval within the specified business day approval window shall result in an administrative denial and write-off absorbed by the executing Meridian Health Partners clinic site.

11.2 Escalations regarding denied authorisations must be submitted in writing to Claims Operations Manager Sarah Jenkins within 10 business days of the adverse determination notice.